



PROVIDENCE ENGLISH PRIVATE SCHOOL

# Digital Citizenship Policy

2026 – 2027

Approved for FS 2 – Year 13

**POLICY REVIEWED BY**

IT Coordinator, Counsellor & Senior Leadership Team

**POLICY REVIEWED DATE**

August 2026

**POLICY APPROVED BY**

School Principal

**NEXT REVIEW DATE**

September 2027

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## 1 Aims & Objectives

Providence English Private School (PEPS) is committed to preparing students to live, learn and communicate safely, respectfully and responsibly in a digital world. As technology becomes increasingly embedded in teaching, learning and everyday life, the school recognises its duty to equip students with the knowledge, skills and values needed to navigate digital spaces with confidence and integrity.

Our aims are:

- To promote the safe, responsible and ethical use of technology by all members of the school community;
- To develop students' digital literacy, critical thinking and information evaluation skills;
- To protect students from online risks including cyberbullying, exploitation, radicalisation and exposure to inappropriate content;

- To foster a positive digital footprint and an awareness of the permanence of online actions;
- To promote balance and wellbeing in students' use of technology;
- To ensure students understand their rights and responsibilities as digital citizens, both within and beyond the school community;
- To support parents in guiding their children's digital habits at home.

## 2 Legal & Regulatory Framework

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This policy is written to align with the following UAE federal, local and regulatory requirements:

- **Sharjah Private Education Authority (SPEA):** e-safety, digital wellbeing and safeguarding standards for private schools;
- **UAE National Education Charter:** the Charter's digital literacy and future-skills pillars, embedded in curriculum and school practice;
- **Ministry of Education Student Code of Conduct:** provisions relating to the responsible use of school-issued devices, platforms and digital communication;
- **Federal Decree-Law No. 34 of 2021 (Cybercrime Law):** governs online harassment, impersonation, defamation and misuse of electronic devices and networks;
- **Federal Law No. 3 of 2016 on Child Rights (Wadeema's Law):** guarantees every child's right to protection from all forms of abuse, including online exploitation and harm;
- **Federal Decree-Law No. 45 of 2021 on the Protection of Personal Data:** governs the collection, processing and protection of personal data, relevant to student data handled on school platforms;
- UAE National Programme for Happiness and Wellbeing and the Ministry of Education's Digital Wellbeing guidance, which inform this policy's approach to healthy technology use.

## 3 Rationale & Definitions

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Digital citizenship refers to the ability to engage with digital technologies in a way that is safe, ethical, informed and respectful of oneself and others. It encompasses online conduct, digital literacy, data privacy, intellectual property, digital wellbeing and the critical evaluation of information.

The school believes that digital citizenship is not a separate subject but a set of values and competencies that should be modelled, taught and reinforced across all year groups and subject areas, in the same way as good conduct is expected in physical spaces.

## 4 Scope & Applicability

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This policy applies to all students at PEPS, from FS 2 to Year 13, and covers:

- Use of the networks, platforms and email/communication systems;
- Use of personal devices brought onto school premises (subject to the Behaviour & Discipline Policy's Mobile Phone / Device rules);
- Online conduct during school-organised activities, including virtual learning and remote/blended learning;
- Conduct in digital spaces — including social media, messaging apps and gaming platforms — outside school hours, where it affects a member of the PEPS community or the reputation of the school;
- Staff use of digital platforms for teaching, communication with parents, and record-keeping.

## 5 Roles & Responsibilities

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## **Teachers**

Teachers are responsible for modelling responsible digital behaviour, embedding digital citizenship into lessons where relevant, supervising students' use of technology during class, and reporting concerns to the Section Supervisor, School Counsellor or Child Protection Coordinator as appropriate.

## **Parents / Guardians**

Parents/Guardians are asked to:

- Monitor and guide their child's use of devices and platforms at home;
- Reinforce the school's expectations around online conduct and screen time balance;
- Report any concerns about cyberbullying, online safety or inappropriate content to the school promptly;
- Support the school's device rules by not enabling access to prohibited apps, sites or communication channels during school hours.

## **Students**

Students are expected to use technology responsibly, treat others with respect online as they would in person, protect their own and others' personal information, and report any incidents of online harm to a trusted adult.

## **The Designated Safeguarding Lead / Child Protection Coordinator**

Oversees the handling of any online safety incident involving suspected harm, exploitation or abuse, in line with the Safeguarding & Child Protection Policy.

# **6 Core Principles of Digital Citizenship at PEPS**

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## **6.1 Respect and Conduct Online**

Students must treat others online with the same courtesy and respect required in Section 6 of the Behaviour & Discipline Policy. Cyberbullying, harassment, impersonation, exclusion or the sharing of hurtful content is strictly forbidden and will be treated as a serious disciplinary matter, dealt with in line with the Anti-Bullying Policy.

## **6.2 Digital Footprint**

Students are taught that online actions leave a lasting digital footprint. The school promotes awareness of how content shared online — including on social media — can affect reputation, safety and future opportunities.

## **6.3 Privacy & Personal Data**

Students must not share personal information (their own or others') such as addresses, phone numbers, passwords or images without consent. Staff and the school will handle student data in line with the Protection of Personal Data Law and the school's Data Protection procedures.

## **6.4 Information Literacy & Academic Integrity**

Students are taught to evaluate online sources critically, distinguish credible information from misinformation, and cite sources appropriately. Plagiarism, use of unauthorised AI tools in ways that breach academic integrity, and the fabrication of sources are treated as breaches of the school's Academic Integrity expectations.

## **6.5 Appropriate Content**

Students must not access, create, or share content that is violent, sexually explicit, discriminatory or otherwise inappropriate, whether on school devices/networks or personal devices on school premises. Filtering and monitoring systems are in place on school networks in line with SPEA guidance.

## **6.6 Digital Wellbeing**

The school encourages a healthy balance between online and offline activity, and will provide guidance to

students and parents on managing screen time, recognising signs of problematic use, and maintaining wellbeing.

## 6.7 Reporting

Any student who experiences or witnesses cyberbullying, online exploitation, grooming or other online harm is encouraged to report it immediately to a Class Teacher, School Counsellor, Social Worker or the Child Protection Coordinator. All such reports will be treated confidentially and in line with the Safeguarding & Child Protection Policy.

## 7 Sanctions

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Breaches of this policy will be addressed in line with the sanctions framework set out in the Behaviour & Discipline Policy, taking into account the age of the student and the seriousness of the breach. Serious breaches — including cyberbullying, sharing of explicit content, hacking, or online threats — may result in suspension, and in the most serious cases, referral to the Board of Management for consideration of expulsion, in line with Sections 13 and 14 of the Behaviour & Discipline Policy. Where a breach may constitute a criminal offence under UAE law, the school reserves the right to involve the relevant authorities.

## 8 Curriculum Integration

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Digital citizenship is embedded across the curriculum through ICT/Computing lessons, tutor time, assemblies, and cross-curricular projects, and reinforced annually through Safer Internet Day activities, parent workshops and student-led initiatives.

## 9 Policy Links

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- Behaviour & Discipline Policy
- Anti-Bullying Policy
- Safeguarding & Child Protection Policy
- E-Safety / Acceptable Use Policy
- Data Protection Policy
- Wellbeing Policy

## 10 Monitoring & Evaluation

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This policy will be reviewed annually by the Senior Leadership Team, IT Coordinator, School Counsellor and Child Protection Coordinator, or sooner if required by changes in SPEA/MOE regulation or UAE federal law.

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| <b>Policy Reviewed By</b>   | IT Coordinator, Counsellor & Senior Leadership Team |
| <b>Policy Reviewed Date</b> | August 2026                                         |
| <b>Policy Approved By</b>   | School Principal                                    |
| <b>Next Review Date</b>     | September 2027                                      |